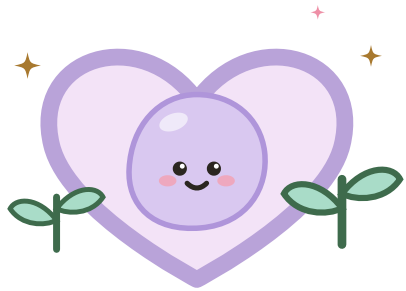
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 2

Heal and Steady

Stress, anger, worry, loss and repair, and finding your footing again



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 2: *Heal and Steady*.
By Christian. Published by Christian's Lab, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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About this book, and how to use it

This book is for the heavy days. It covers stress, sleep and rest, anger, worry, low mood and trauma, grief, repair after hurt, the slow work of change, and what matters to you.

It is for anyone going through a hard stretch, and for anyone standing beside someone who is. Each chapter says plainly when it is time to get help from a doctor, counsellor or helpline, and how to find one.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Stress and the nervous system	…/book/understanding-2-stress
Chapter 2	Anger	…/book/understanding-13-anger
Chapter 3	Worry, low mood and trauma	…/book/understanding-16-worry
Chapter 4	Loss, grief and big life changes	…/book/understanding-8-loss
Chapter 5	Healing after hurt	…/book/understanding-11-healing
Chapter 6	Habits and change	…/book/understanding-6-change
Chapter 7	Values, meaning and a good life	…/book/understanding-10-values

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, about yourself; Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, about understanding the people around you; Book 4, *Share the Load*, about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 1, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

You feel flooded and can't think straight	Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system	9
Small things make you snap	Chapter 2 · Anger	29
Worry keeps you awake	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	49
Your mood has been low for weeks	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	49
Something frightening happened and it hasn't left you	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	49
Someone has died, or life changed all at once	Chapter 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes	69
You hurt someone, or someone hurt you	Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt	85
You keep starting good habits and dropping them	Chapter 6 · Habits and change	105
You've lost sight of what matters to you	Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life	121

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-02 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-02: How much are you carrying?”. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music”. You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, a raindrop in a mortarboard, gives most of the hints, and answers questions on the website.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, points you at something to try.



Sugarfoot, the slower, steadier pup, turns up when a page needs a calmer pace.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

FROM THE PERSON WHO MADE THIS

> *“I spent my career as a government auditor and audit manager in tax enforcement, internal controls and compliance.” “Everyone else seemed to have been handed a set of instructions about being human that nobody ever gave me, so I went looking for them myself.” “Everything here exists so that you can do the same thing in far less time than it took me.”*

Christian, quoted from the About page at spreadloveandacceptance.com/about. Where the chapters say “I”, they speak for the website and these books; any fact about Christian in them comes from that page.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Book 3, Chapter 7, page 115 says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 3, page **64** about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 1

Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they're flooded, and which kinds of rest actually put something back.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

MONDAY, 7:52AM

The bus is late. One school shoe is missing, last seen under the sofa on Saturday, and your phone buzzes with a message from work that begins "Quick one". Your partner calls from the hall, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself snap, "I'm not your secretary!"

A second later you wonder where that came from, because the keys were never the problem and you were running late before

> *anyone said a word, before the shoe went missing, probably before you were even out of bed.*

Feelings got their own chapter (Book 1, Chapter 4, page 63). This one goes a layer down, to the nervous system that runs underneath them, and what it does when the pressure is on. Knowing how stress works won't make a busy Monday any quieter. It does make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

It also explains why some of the tools elsewhere work at all. The stress tank in Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) asks you to check how full you are before you judge the moment, because stress piles up from small loads. The Calm-Down Kit in Book 1, Chapter 2 (page 25) settles the body before any words, and it asks you to name a time to come back, so a pause doesn't look like walking out. The setup score in Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27) counts stress as well as hours, since a split can look fair on paper and still leave one person running on empty.

01

Stress is your body getting ready.

Something needs dealing with, and your body gears up before you've decided anything. Heart faster, breath quicker, muscles tight, stress hormones up. That's exactly what you want when a glass is sliding off the table. The trouble comes when the body stays geared up for hours and never gets the signal to stand down.

Morag is a nurse. She handles a cardiac arrest on the ward calmly and well, goes home at nine, eats half a sandwich standing up, and at half past ten finds herself crying at an advert for car insurance, which has never before moved her to anything, while her body carries on running the emergency it thinks she is still in.

So after something stressful, give your body a clear sign that it's over. A walk round the block works, or a hot shower, or one song played loud in the car on the way home; the body takes its cue from what you do far more than from what you tell it.

02

Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same deadline lands on two colleagues on a Thursday afternoon. One has a quiet evening and a takeaway menu. The other has a seven-year-old at home with a temperature and a partner away in Leeds until Saturday. On paper it's one task. Guess which one is awake at 3am.

Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you've got to meet it with, whether that's time, energy, money, help, skill or sleep. That's why a small thing tips you over on a bad day. It's also why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the job at all.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "It's less the task than how little I've got left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

When something feels huge, I'd write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you've got, and then ignore the first list for a minute and ask what would make the second one a line longer.

03

The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture of the states your body moves between in a day. Near the bottom you're **calm and connected**, breathing easily and able to hear something hard without bristling. Higher up you're **revved up**, tense, and small things start to feel urgent or

personal. Then there's **running on empty**, which feels flat and slow, with the words just out of reach.

Most people go up and down it many times a day. A grandfather minding his toddler granddaughter is calm at two o'clock, revved up by four (she has found the felt-tips) and running on empty by six. Neither of them has changed. Only the hour has, and how much afternoon is left in him.

The Nervous System Ladder is a thirty-second check that gives you a best guess at where you are. If you'd rather not use a screen, set three reminders on your phone for today and, each time one goes off, notice which rung you're on and do nothing else about it.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I'm revved up right now." "I'm running on empty. Can this wait till the morning?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)
Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann

The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · Gusty: Revved up · *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · *Someone I care for* · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · Building · *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · About enough · Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work · Money · *Kids or caring* · *Health* · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · *Rest* · To move · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

Fogged in today
Running on empty · Very little room today

Talk window
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: "I'm at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?"

A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

When you're flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve your body is in full alarm, and the things a hard conversation needs most (careful thinking, listening, seeing the other side) get much harder to reach. Lots of people call this being **flooded**. You might say something you don't mean, freeze, or want nothing except to be out of the room.

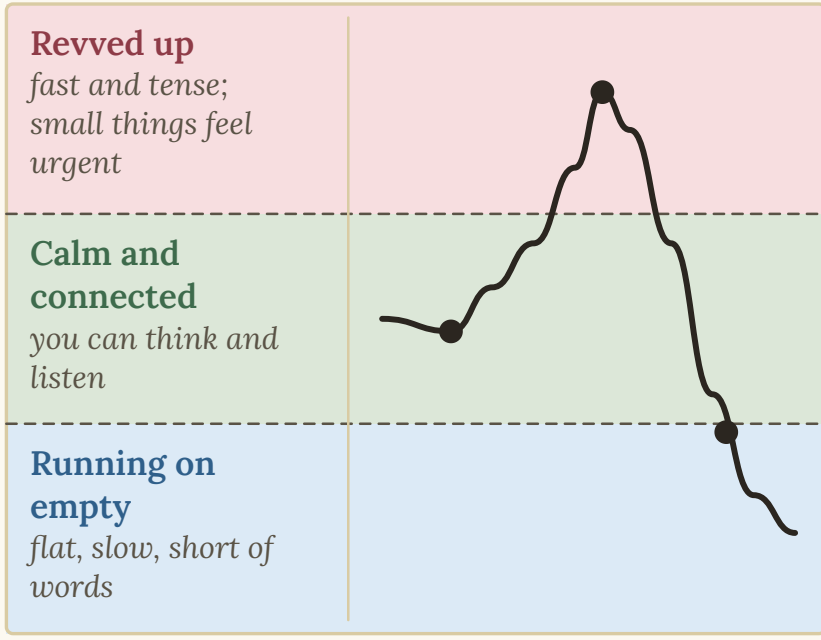
Two adult siblings start sorting their late father's things one wet Saturday. Within twenty minutes they're shouting about a standard lamp that neither of them even likes. The real subject, that he's gone, sits in the boxes around them and nobody says it.

A flooded person is still a decent person whose body has to come down before the talk can go anywhere. It helps to know your own flood signs in advance. Heat in the face is common. So is a racing heart, or the room narrowing, or a voice in your head that has gone very loud and very certain. Notice two at once and you have your cue to stop.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

The ladder: three everyday states

You move up and down it all day.



Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.

Hard talks go best from the middle band.

Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.

FIGURE 1 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

05

Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Picture a tank that holds everything you're already carrying today. The traffic goes in. So does the meeting that overran, the noisy shop, the text from your mum that just says "Call me when you can." It's all one tank, and by the evening something tiny makes it overflow and gets the blame for the whole lot.

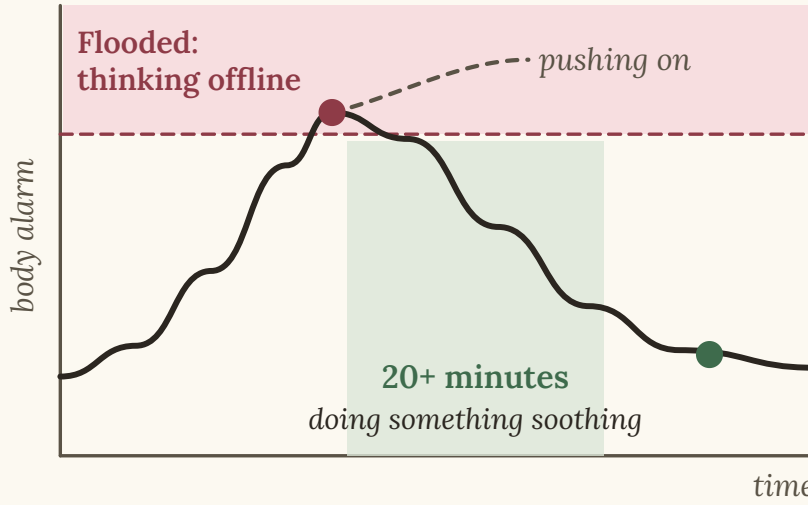
A fifteen-year-old explodes when he's asked to empty the dishwasher. Later, from a friend's mum at the school gate, his own mum finds out that his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime, over something said in a group chat, and the dishwasher had simply been the next thing anyone asked of him.

Small daily hassles count as much as big events here, which surprises people. (I can fill mine in one loud restaurant. That's how I'm wired, and the About page on the website says more.) Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask how full you were before it happened. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) has a quick way to tell.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "My tank was full before I got home. That wasn't really about you." "Rough day? You don't have to explain."

Flooded means offline

Pause, settle, then come back.



- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.

FIGURE 2 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long spell of rain. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

06

Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm, but you can help the body come down, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths works for a lot of people. So does moving, humming something you know by heart, steady pressure like a heavy blanket, or just leaving the noisy room. What works is personal, which is why it's worth finding your own short list on a calm day rather than in the middle of a row. A manager feels her heart going before she has to give some difficult feedback, so she walks once round the car park, breathing out slowly, and goes in a little steadier than she would have been.

Put your list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit helps you build it, and if you only keep one line from this section, keep "body first, words second".

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

07

Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the sofa scrolling can leave you more tired than when you sat down. That's because recovery comes in different kinds. There's sleep, and there's switching off from work in your head, and real relaxation, and doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and the plain feeling of being in charge of your own time, and none of them stands in for the others.

Two housemates have friends round on a Saturday night for a curry and the quiz on the telly. One wakes up on Sunday refreshed. The other spends the whole of Sunday alone with a library book and the door shut, and comes out at teatime feeling like herself again. Company restores some people and drains others, and neither of them is doing rest wrong.

Ask yourself which kind of tired you are: body-tired, people-tired, brain-tired or feelings-tired. Then pick a rest that matches, rather than the one you always default to.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I need quiet rest tonight rather than people rest. It isn't about you." "What kind of tired are you?"



SUGARFOOT

Rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of quiet music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it somewhere you can reach it.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress land harder. After a short or broken night, small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter and people pull away from each other. This one is well studied. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), couples reported more conflict after nights of poor sleep. In experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier.

Saoirse comes off her third night shift at the care home and bursts into tears over a parking ticket. Her sister says, "You've barely slept. Let's sort it out on Thursday." By Thursday it's a parking ticket again, annoying and payable, and she pays it online during her lunch break.

You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story. Before a hard conversation, ask whether you've both slept, and if you haven't, pick another time. At night, try the same few calm steps before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor, because sleep problems are common and often treatable.

YOU COULD SAY

"I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

09

Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other down. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder, or just a quiet person in the same room can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud helps too, because "I'm stressed about work" stops your partner wondering whether it's about them.

A father tells his ten-year-old over fish fingers, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my grown-up job, and you're not in trouble." Over the next few days the boy stops tiptoeing round him and starts bringing his maths homework to the table again.

Tonight, tell one person your state in one sentence, then ask how they are and listen to the answer.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm stressed, and it isn't about you." "Would a hug help, or some space?"

MONDAY, 7:58AM

Six minutes after the snap, your partner is by the door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry," you say. "My tank was full before you opened your mouth. Your keys are on the bathroom shelf, by the way." They laugh and ask if it's been a rough start. The bus is still late. The shoe is still missing. But the two of you are on the same side of the morning again.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Snapping when hungry or tired

FROM OUTSIDE A small question at the end of a long day gets a sharp answer.

THE LOGIC Patience runs on fuel → Hunger and tiredness drain the tank → With an empty tank, small things feel big → The snap is the fuel gauge talking

IT'S LIKE A phone on 3% that starts closing apps.

WHY IT FITS Poor sleep is linked with more conflict the next day, and hunger can colour our judgements without our noticing.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who asked did nothing wrong, and the tone still lands on them.

YOU COULD SAY *"I'm running on empty. Can we talk after I've eaten?"*

ONE SMALL STEP Eat first. Then come back and say sorry for the tone.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hungry-tired-snap

In everyday life

Living on your own means nobody's there to notice when you're running on empty, so build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, plus the rule that whoever pauses names a time to come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space, spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw, has more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is something they borrow for years before they can make their own. And at work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, so waiting an hour usually beats pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, like shift work, a long-term illness or caring for someone. What that calls for is a different setup. More effort won't do it (see Different

hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and Caregivers, spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers). If you have ADHD, keeping track of everything can quietly fill the tank before breakfast. Get the remembering out of your head and into the world, with labelled alarms and one hook for the keys, and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: make a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
Caregivers
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

Common mix-ups

People often think all stress is bad. It isn't. Short bursts help you rise to a challenge, and the harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery. Others think that being calm means not being upset, when you can be calm and sad, or calm and very firm. Pausing gets mistaken for avoiding, but a pause with a time to come back is how you finish a talk well, and avoiding is the pause that never comes back. Rest gets called lazy, though bodies and minds that never recover tend to break down. And short replies with a flat face are read as not caring, when far more often they mean someone is worn out.

If you want to help someone else with this

Nobody in the history of the world has calmed down because they were told to. A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence do

far more. So does taking one job off someone's list, which beats any pep talk. Ask what kind of help they'd like (practical help, company, a distraction or some space) instead of guessing. Don't debate with someone who's flooded; offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, say so kindly and help them find support.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight away);
- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that is happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave, that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder: a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now?: steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift, Brain Breakers and calm games: gentle ways to come down.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

ONLINE
Drift
spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer

TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

ONLINE
calm games
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play

More for your situation

- Book 4, Chapter 3: full tanks and different angles (page 51)
- How to stop fighting: calm steps
- New baby, sharing the load and Coming home after time apart
- For teens: big feelings and stress
- Sensory overload at home
- Help by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
How to stop fighting: calm steps
spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner

ONLINE
New baby, sharing the load
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
For teens: big feelings and stress
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Sensory overload at home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Stress is your body getting ready.
- ✓ The ladder: three everyday states.
- ✓ Stress adds up, like a tank filling.
- ✓ Rest isn't one thing.
- ✓ Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Share the Load, page 51
The stress tank in a shared home

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words — Know Yourself Kindly, page 25
Your weather before you speak

Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune — Understanding Each Other, page 9
How stress knocks two people out of tune

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma — page 49
When stress turns into worry or low mood

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth

2

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 2

Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

Your brother texts: "Can't do Thursday after all, sorry!! Work thing." Thursday is Mum's hospital appointment, the one with the consultant, and this is the third time this month. Your jaw sets. Your face goes hot. Your thumbs are already typing "TYPICAL. You never…" and the message is one tap from sent.

Plenty of us were taught that anger was rude or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is a normal

human feeling, though, and it very often points at something real. This chapter looks at how it works and then at what to do with it. It also sits under two tools elsewhere: the Calm-Down Kit (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25), which works because anger rises in the body first and slowing the body is what makes words possible, and letting a comment land before you react (Book 4, Chapter 4, page 73), which is the step back described further on.

01

Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says that something is unfair, that someone is in your way, or that a line has been crossed. It pushes you *towards* a problem so you'll change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or come out far bigger than the problem in front of it.

Somebody keeps eating Shabnam's lunch from the office fridge. Week one, she assumes a mistake. Week two, she writes her name on the box in marker pen. By week three her anger has told her clearly that a line has been crossed, and it's the anger, frankly, that gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting. (It was the new starter. He thought the fridge was communal. He bought her a meal deal.) Next time you're angry, finish this sentence privately: "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

02

Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than what sits under it, whether that's hurt or fear or shame or plain tiredness. Book 1, Chapter 4 (page 63) calls this layers. The layer underneath usually tells you what you actually need.

A father snaps at his sixteen-year-old for coming in an hour late. Under the anger is an hour spent at the front window, phone in

hand, imagining the worst. When he tells her about that hour instead of the curfew, she hears it, and says sorry, and means it.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across cross, but I think I'm actually hurt."

03

Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart, a voice getting louder: that's the body getting ready for a fight, and it can happen in seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking gets much harder, and so does listening. Chapter 1 (page 9) calls this being flooded, when you're so stirred up that the thinking part of you goes quiet for a while.

Halfway through an argument about whose turn it was to put the bins out, a woman notices her hands are shaking and realises she hasn't heard a word her housemate has said for at least a minute. That's her sign to stop. Learn your own early signs, two or three of them, like a tight jaw or talking faster, and treat them as your cue to slow down.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

04

In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking, or typing. Breathe out slowly, so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath. Unclench your hands, and if you can, move away for a while. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

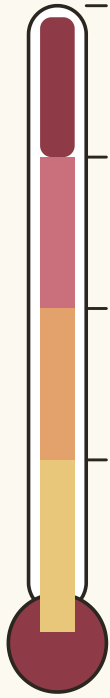
A dad feels his temper going while he helps with fractions homework at the kitchen table. He says, "I'm getting frustrated, and that's not your fault. I'm going to get a glass of water and come back in five minutes." He comes back in five, and they finish the sheet together, and both of them get number six wrong.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm too angry to talk well right now. I'll come back at eight." "I need ten minutes. I'm coming back to this conversation."

Make the plan on a calm day: your early sign, the words you'll say, and where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? has steps for the hottest moments.

Anger rises fast

What helps depends on how hot it is.



Hot minutes
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

Angry
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

Annoyed
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

Irritated
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.
Then repair any sharp moments.

In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.

FIGURE 3 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The Calm-Down Kit

Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13

The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
Pat (Nan)

Date
4 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
Door slammed after a call with his mum	*Shoulders up by my ears*
Being shouted at in front of the neighbours	*Hot face, can't find words*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Gating (lower the lights, step out)

Second, if the first isn't available
Low, steady sound

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
"Kettle time"

The shortest break we take
20 minutes

How we set the time to come back
Whoever pauses says a time before they go

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
5:10 pm	*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next

Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action

Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up

After tea, at 6

☑ I'm going with this

Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

05

Letting rip doesn't empty it.

A lot of people believe anger works like steam, so that shouting or slamming a door or hitting a pillow lets it out and leaves you calmer. It's a lovely tidy idea, and the research doesn't support it. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger fades faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

After a row with a colleague, a man spends his lunch break telling three different people how awful she is, and by the afternoon he's angrier than he was at noon. The next time it happens he walks to the river and back instead, and by two o'clock he can think about the actual problem. If you catch yourself replaying an argument, set a timer for twenty minutes, do something absorbing, then come back to it.

06

Step back and look from the outside.

Once your body has settled a bit, try looking at the moment as if you were watching from across the room. What happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall", instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

Furious that a friend has cancelled again, a woman imagines telling the whole story to a kind stranger on a train. Telling it that way, she remembers that her friend is caring for her dad, who has been in and out of hospital since June, and the anger turns slowly into worry. One way in is to write two lines about the moment with your own name instead of "I": "Wes got angry because…" It feels odd. It also works.

07

Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you're calmer you can still say you were angry, and why, without attacking anyone. A simple shape helps: what happened, how you felt, what you're asking for.

So instead of "You always let me down," a woman says to her sister, "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again, I felt really angry and alone with it. Can we make a plan for who takes her over the next three months?" It's longer. It's also the only version that ends with a plan. Write your angry message, then rewrite it in that shape before you send anything. Book 3, Chapter 2 (page 25) has more on saying hard things.

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?" "When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."



SUGARFOOT

Say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it far easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
soften a tense moment
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/tools/
soften-a-tense-moment

08

After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a great deal. A short, real repair rebuilds trust, and it means naming what you did without a "but", then saying what you'll do differently.

A grandmother shouts at her grandson when the blue vase from the hall table ends up in pieces, and he cries. An hour later she sits beside him on the stairs and says, "I shouted, and that was scary. You matter far more to me than the vase. I'm sorry." He leans against her shoulder for a bit and then asks whether they can glue it. They try. It now has a visible crack and lives on the landing. Is there a recent moment when your anger landed on someone, and a short repair you could still make? Chapter 5 (page 85) has more on apologies that land.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry."
> "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

09

When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, shouting so someone is scared, or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example, a man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

TRY THIS.

If this sounds like you, see Find a counsellor or therapist and the Cool-down corner. If you're afraid of someone else's anger, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

You put the phone face down on the arm of the sofa and walk round the block, breathing out long. Somewhere near the postbox on the corner you notice what's under the anger. You're tired, and you're frightened about Mum. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel alone with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"

He reads it at 6:52. By ten o'clock there's still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who'll drive her on Thursday. You sent the message you can stand behind. That part is done, even if the rest of it isn't.

If you're a teenager

Maisie is sixteen, and at ten o'clock her dad takes her phone, right in the middle of a group chat about Saturday. She shouts and slams her bedroom door hard enough to rattle the picture on the landing. The next morning, calmer, she tells him it felt as if he didn't trust her, says sorry for the door, and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He agrees, and adds that he'd much rather hear this over breakfast than through a door.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and arguments often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Getting upset over something "small"

FROM OUTSIDE After a long day, a cup left on the side leads to an outburst.

THE LOGIC Stress adds up all day → Each thing fills a glass a little more → The cup is the last drop → What spills is the whole glass

IT'S LIKE One more breath into a balloon that was already full.

WHY IT FITS The last small thing often gets the reaction that belongs to the whole day.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who left the cup gets a whole day poured over them.

YOU COULD SAY *"It's not just the cup. It's been a heavy day."*

ONE SMALL STEP Say early when the glass is getting full. Afterwards, apologise for the size of the reaction.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-straw

In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts too. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward, and it helps to talk to yourself the way you would to a friend who'd made the same mistake (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 81,

goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more than anything we say about it. At work anger is common and rarely spoken, and "I'm frustrated about the deadline change. Can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can arrive fast and big and then go just as quickly, so plan for the speed: a three-word pause line like "Back in ten", and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you're managing a clash between two other people, hear each of them alone first and then together, always about what happened and never about each other. The fight is often about the setup, two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example.

Common mix-ups

Anger itself isn't a bad feeling. It's normal and it carries information; it's some of the things done in anger that cause harm. Letting it out isn't the healthy option it sounds like, because shouting or hitting things tends to keep anger going. "They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted" mixes up two things: someone can do something unfair, and what you do next is still yours. And holding it in isn't as safe as it looks. Anger swallowed for years tends to come out sideways, as coldness or sarcasm or a sudden explosion over a teaspoon, so saying it calmly and early is the safer route.

If you want to help someone else with this

Keep yourself safe first. If someone's anger scares you, step away; you don't have to stay and calm them down. Otherwise speak lower and slower, and leave the argument until they've come down.

Then listen for the message under it. There's often something fair in there, and you can take that part seriously while still saying that the way it was said wasn't okay.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" "I can tell this really matters to you."

When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do. Find a counsellor or therapist lists places to start, some of them free, and the Cool-down corner helps in the hot minutes.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists

free, private help. If you or anyone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
- For teens
- Family rifts · Caring for someone you love
- At work
- Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- ✓ **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- ✓ **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.
- ✓ **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Share the Load, page 51
Leftover stress behind a reaction

Book 1, Chapter 4 · How feelings work — Know Yourself Kindly, page 63
Feelings as signals

Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt — page 85
Repair after the hot minutes

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly, page 47
A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth

3

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 3

Worry, low mood and trauma

How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 1 (page 9). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.

- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice and the back door once. Tomorrow is the hospital appointment, ten o'clock, and the same three thoughts keep going round: what if it's bad, what if you can't cope, what if there's nobody to tell. Your chest is tight and your mind won't stop. And if you're honest, you haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks now. Even answering messages has started to feel like too much.

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people the feelings settle by themselves. For others they stick, and grow, until they shape every day. This chapter explains how they work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you aren't alone, and things can get better.

Some tools elsewhere in the books lean on this chapter. The daily check-in's "low, medium or high" (Book 3, Chapter 1, page 9) lets the people around you adjust when worry or low mood has shrunk the room you have. "A full tank means later, not never" (Book 4, Chapter 3, page 51) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going. And picking one small goal (Book 1, Chapter

3, page 47) suits low mood, since doing very often comes before feeling better.

01

Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that is here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen, and worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" on repeat. All three run through the stress system described in Chapter 1 (page 9): a racing heart, a tight chest, shallow breathing, a churning stomach, poor sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is that it can be set too sensitive, and it can't tell a real tiger from a worrying email.

A fifteen-year-old's heart pounds before every presentation in class. Nothing bad has ever happened in one. Her alarm still treats a room of her own classmates, half of whom she's known since primary school, as a dangerous place. When worry rises, breathe out slowly five times, each out-breath longer than the in-breath, then name three things you can see. It tells the body that the danger isn't here right now.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "This is my alarm talking, and alarms can be wrong." "My body is getting ready to protect me. I can thank it and carry on."

02

Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was a good idea. So next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to learn that you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014)

describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on the number 42, a man starts walking everywhere, even in the rain, even the three miles to work. With his sister beside him he rides one stop, then two. Some weeks later he does the whole journey into town, and his brain has slowly learned that buses are survivable. Pick one small thing you've been avoiding, break it into three steps from easiest to hardest, and do the easiest one this week.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "What do I think will happen? Let's see what actually happens."
> "Uncomfortable isn't the same as dangerous."

03

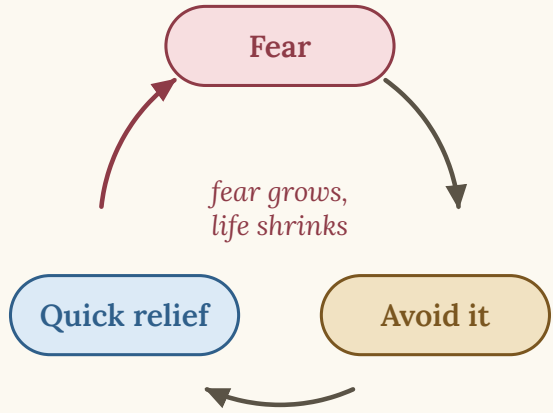
Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps a lot of people is postponing it: you notice a worry, write it down, and save it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, ask of each worry whether there's something you can do about it. If there is, plan one step. If there isn't, practise letting it go.

A man caring for his own father keeps a worry notebook by the kettle, a small red one. At six in the evening he gives it fifteen minutes with a cup of tea, and by then many of the morning's worries already look smaller, and a couple have sorted themselves out. Choose a fifteen-minute worry time well before bed.

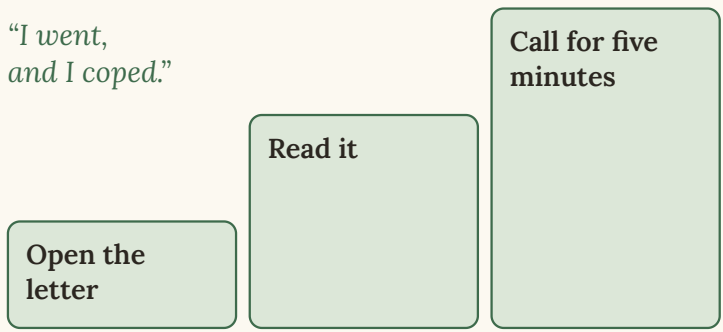
Avoiding keeps fear going

Quick relief now, a smaller life later.



The way back: small, planned steps

*"I went,
and I coped."*



Planned, gradual approach (exposure) is among the most effective treatments for anxiety; it builds new learning that competes with the old fear (Craske and colleagues, 2014). A therapist can help with strong fears.

FIGURE 4 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"Noted. I'll think about that at six." "Can I do anything about this today? If not, it can wait."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Flip it

Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam

Flip it

What's on your mind?

What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | A *worry* | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

The best outcome would be
[what you hope for]

The main thing in the way
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

If that happens, I'll
[one small thing you could do]

One step today
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version

Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.

When the worry comes back at 1am

It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.

If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Small wins: Flip it

spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a disappointment is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, changes in appetite, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness. It can also look like irritability, or simply running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

A retired teacher notices he has stopped going to his Thursday walking group, isn't reading, and wakes at four every morning. He tells himself he's just getting old, until his daughter, on a visit,

gently suggests it might be depression and that depression can be treated. If you've felt low or lost interest most days for two weeks or more, book a talk with a doctor this week, and write down what you've noticed to take with you.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness." "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

05

Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood tells you to wait until you feel like it. Withdrawing makes life emptier, though, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round: you plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure or a sense of having done something, and you do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

A woman living alone after her divorce plans three small things a day: a ten-minute walk to the postbox and back, one call or message, and one job she can finish, like wiping the hob. Some days they feel pointless. She does them anyway. Over a few weeks the days begin to feel less flat, though she couldn't tell you which day it changed. Tomorrow, try three tiny things of your own, one for pleasure, one for connection and one you can finish.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I don't have to feel like it to do it." "Small counts."

06

Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter. The evidence for them is solid. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups protects as well. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse. A new dad who is exhausted and flat agrees with his partner on one protected long sleep each at the weekend, a pram walk every morning, and his old Wednesday five-a-side. Pick whichever of the three is most off for you right now and make one small change to it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

Months after a car crash on a wet roundabout, a woman still jumps at screeching brakes and won't drive after dark. Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger and hasn't yet unlearned it, which is a long way from overreacting. If something frightening happened more than a month ago and it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "My reactions make sense after what happened." "It's in the past, even if my body doesn't feel that yet."

08

After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. A review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first, and the same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

After a break-in, a grandmother doesn't want to talk about it. Her grandson doesn't push. He fixes the back-door lock, stays the night on her sofa, and says, "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here." A week later, over the phone, she does.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "You don't have to tell me anything. What would help right now?" "You're safe now. I'm staying."

09

Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It's one of the most studied talking therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting,

changing or stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

A young man is too embarrassed to ask for help with panic attacks, until one stops him getting on the 7.40 for the second week running. His GP refers him to a short course of CBT, and after eight sessions he's taking the train to work again, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days. Before an appointment, it helps to write three lines: what you've noticed, how long it has lasted, and what it's stopping you doing.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while."
> "What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope from the gas board and told them they could wait until today, and you slept a little. This morning you breathe out long at the kitchen window, then text your neighbour: "Hospital at ten. A bit scared. Fancy a cuppa after?"

She replies with three hearts and says of course. The appointment is still the appointment. You won't be facing it on your own, though. Looking at the envelope again, you notice how many weeks it's been since you felt like yourself, and you add one more line at the bottom, to ask the doctor about your mood as well.

If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all pile up at once, usually at about one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep the night before a chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step (ask Mr Okafor about question types) and puts her phone on the landing. The next day she tells her mum, and it helps more than she expected it to.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor. Under 19 in the UK, you can call Childline free on 0800 1111.

YOU COULD SAY

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Asking for reassurance again and again

FROM OUTSIDE "Are you sure you're not angry with me?" for the fourth time tonight.

THE LOGIC Doubt feels like danger → Reassurance turns the alarm off for a moment → Then the alarm comes back → Asking again is trying to turn it off again

IT'S LIKE Going back to check the front door is locked.

WHY IT FITS Uncertainty can feel unbearable when you're anxious, and asking brings real relief, even if it is brief.

THE OTHER SIDE Answering again and again is tiring, and it can keep the loop going.

YOU COULD SAY *"My worry keeps coming back. Asking turns it down for a bit."*

ONE SMALL STEP Agree a kind limit together. One clear answer, then something calming to do side by side. If the worry runs your days, a GP can help.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=reassurance

In everyday life

Living alone can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day is worth protecting, even a two-minute call (see On your own: when it's lonely, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, low mood can look like not caring and anxiety can look like nagging, so name it plainly: "I'm low today, and I'm not cross with you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on repeat. A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling. Keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 4 (page 69) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a

short, honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, so make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On your own: when it's lonely
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

Anxiety doesn't mean something is wrong with you. It's a normal alarm, and it only becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life. Depression isn't just sadness, and nobody snaps out of it; it affects sleep, energy, thinking and the body as well as mood, and many people recover with the right help. Not everything bad that happens is trauma in the clinical sense, which usually means a threat to life or safety, but other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair. Talking about trauma straight away doesn't help everyone. Some people want to and some don't, forcing it can make things worse, and safety and choice come first.

And asking someone about suicide does not put the idea in their head. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

Notice, and ask. “You’ve seemed low lately. How are you doing, really?” opens the door, and after that it helps to listen more than you talk. Leave the feeling alone rather than arguing with it; “Cheer up” and “It could be worse” push people away, while “That sounds really hard” keeps them close. Offer something specific, like a walk, a meal, a lift to the doctor or an evening on the sofa together, because a small practical offer is much easier to accept than a big vague one.

Ask directly about safety if you’re worried. “Are you having thoughts of ending your life?” If yes, stay with them, and get help together today. And look after yourself too, because supporting someone who is struggling is tiring (see Book 3, Chapter 7, page 115).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> “I’m not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I’m here.”
> “Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?”

When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you’ve felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you’re avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you’re using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you’re not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;

- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or you are in danger, get help now. Call your local emergency number (911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 in most of Europe). In the US, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, or text HOME to 741741. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258.

In Canada, call or text 988. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Under 19 in the UK? Childline is free on 0800 1111. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines in your country. More are on Someone to talk to, free.

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first. Find a counsellor or therapist has more places to start. If someone at home is hurting or frightening you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Someone to talk to, free · Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today: a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life
- For teens · For parents · New parents
- Caring for someone you love

- At work
- Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **Related chapters:** Stress (Chapter 1, page 9) · Self-worth and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 81) · Healing (Chapter 5, page 85)
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On your own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents



ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system page 9
The stress ladder and rest

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion Know Yourself Kindly, page 81
A kinder inner voice

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well Understanding Each Other, page 115
Supporting someone who is struggling

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth

4

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 4

Loss, grief and big life changes

What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

Six months on, you're doing fine, or so you tell people. Then in aisle seven you see the cereal your dad always bought, the one with the faded blue box that he said tasted of cardboard and ate every single morning anyway, and you have to leave your trolley where it is and go and sit in the car. Nobody around you knows why.

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something, whether a person, a pet, a marriage, a friendship, their health, a home, a job, a country or a future they had pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There's no right way to grieve. Nothing here is a timetable, and if any of it doesn't fit you, leave it.

01

Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted away or children leaving home can all bring real grief. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever other people think the loss ought to mean.

When Bramble dies, his owner is shaken by how hard he takes it, and his friends at the pub tell him, kindly enough, that it was only a dog. That dog walked beside him along the same stretch of river every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce. The lead is still on its hook by the back door, and he can't move it yet.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you've never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship." "I'm grieving the

life we planned." They're small sentences, and they often bring some relief, because they give the feeling a name and a reason.

02

Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone follows in order. Most people swing back and forth, some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and researchers who study grief see that swing as healthy. A widow laughs properly over a jacket potato with her sister on a Wednesday, feels guilty about it on the bus home, and cries all evening. The lunch was grief too.

A small break from grief, a walk or a programme you like or a meal with a friend, takes nothing away from the person you lost. And when a wave comes, it does usually pass, even if it knocks you over first.

03

Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, poor sleep, no appetite or extra appetite, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there has gone, and that learning takes time and uses energy. A deputy head whose mother has died loses her car keys three times in one week and walks into a governors' meeting on the wrong day, and she starts to worry that something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog. It eases as the months pass, though nobody can tell her exactly when.

While it lasts, protect a few basics: one regular meal, a set bedtime, a short walk outside. It's fine to tell people at work or at home, "I'm

grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

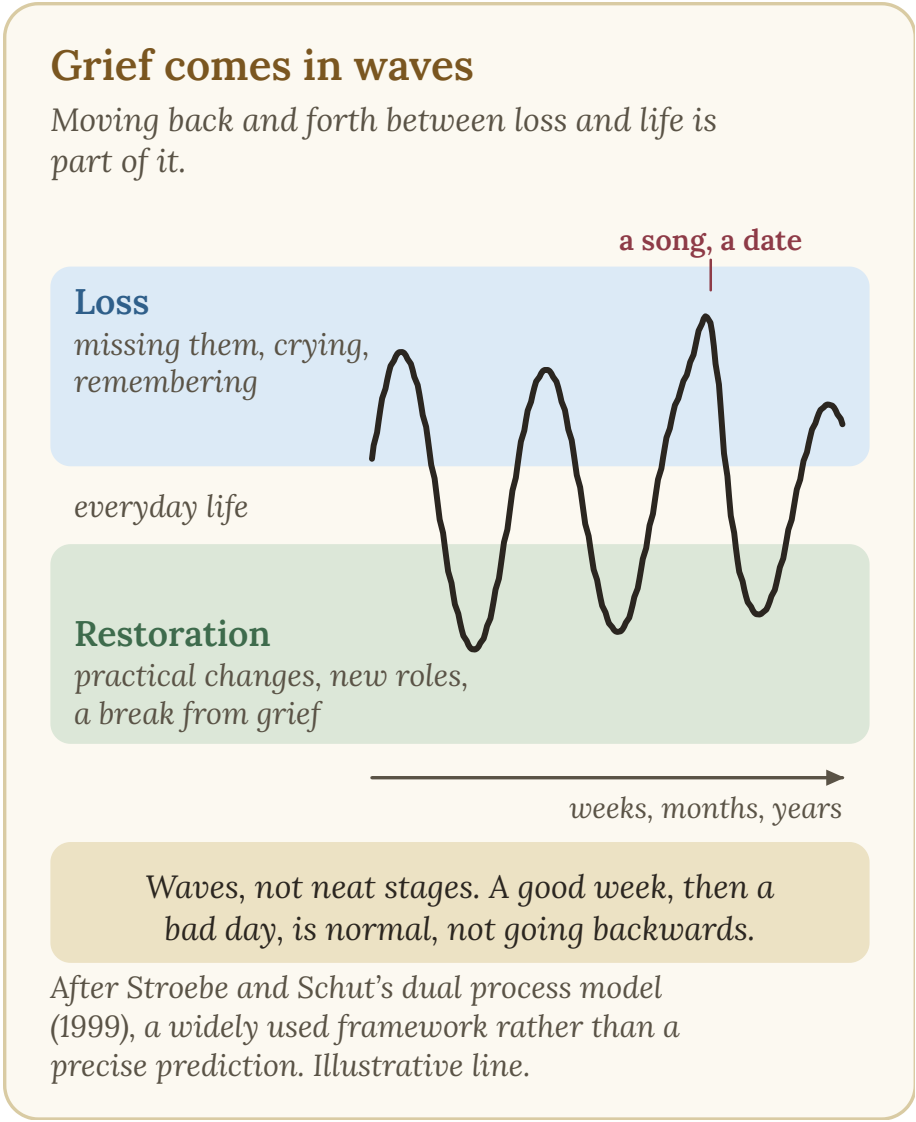


FIGURE 5 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

04

Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed by dementia or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Other losses go unrecognised, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online. A woman whose father has dementia still visits him at the care home every Sunday at two. He's pleased to see her. He thinks she's his sister. The dad who knew her is fading, and she is grieving someone who hasn't died, which is a very lonely kind of grief because there's no ceremony for it and hardly anyone notices.

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one of your own by lighting a candle, writing a letter, planting something or visiting a place that mattered. You might also tell one person, "I'm grieving something people might not see as a loss. It is one for me."

05

People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying, and others by doing, whether that means fixing things, organising, working or building something. Neither way is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't grieving, when they're grieving differently, and culture, faith, age and how your mind works all shape the way it comes out. After their son's death, one parent wants to talk about him every evening. The other spends every weekend in the garage, restoring the old Raleigh he never got round to fixing. Each feels the other is getting it wrong. Each is grieving the same boy.

A question can bridge the gap. "What has helped you most, even a little?" asked of someone who shares your loss, and listened to

without correcting, often shows that the two of you want the same thing by different roads.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Write it through

Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Malcolm and Fiona

Your name (optional)
Mum

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.

How I feel about it

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

You don't have to let go.

An older idea said that healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and values they carry forward, so the relationship changes shape without having to end. A teenager wears her grandfather's watch to every exam, a heavy old thing that she has to push up her arm to write. She doesn't believe in luck, and she'd find it hard to explain why the watch matters, except that it feels as if he's in the room.

You might choose one way of keeping a bond, such as cooking their recipe, telling a story about them at a family meal or keeping one of their habits. Some people find it helps to ask, in a hard moment, what the person they lost would have said.

07

Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retirement, moving country, a child starting school, coming out or getting well after a long illness can all bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing time in between and a new beginning, and the middle part is both the hardest and the easiest to rush. A couple move to Bristol for a job they both wanted. Six months in, one of them feels low, then guilty for feeling low, because this was the plan and they'd toasted it with fizz. What they also lost was a circle of friends, a café where nobody had to ask what they wanted, and a whole way of life.

You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before. For one change you are going through, it may help to write down what ended, what still feels unclear and one small thing that is new and good.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a change is hard to talk about, writing can come first. This is a quiet place to put the words down, at your own pace, and to send them only if you want to.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/write-it-through

08

Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that, over time, many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, even though they never forget. Being with people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it. A year after his wife died, a man still can't go into their bedroom or face his friends, and his doctor refers him to a grief counsellor. Things begin to move, slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's, where they watch the snooker and don't talk much.

On a good day, write down two people you could text on a hard one, and one place you could call if those people aren't enough. If it has been a long time and nothing is easing, it is reasonable to say, "I think I need more help."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

You sit in the car for ten minutes and let the wave come. Then you go back in. Your trolley is where you left it, next to the porridge, and you put the cereal in. At home you text your sister that you saw Dad's cereal and cried in the car park. She replies straight away that the same thing happened to her with his aftershave in a chemist's, and asks whether you can call tonight.

Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, from the empty chair to the jobs that were always theirs, the paperwork done alone and the first birthday and anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time, and let one drawer count as a day's work. It is fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill in the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you have lost a partner, and you may grieve on different timetables. If they start checking on you every day, that comes from love and worry. It isn't control. You can still say what helps: "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

In everyday life

After a miscarriage, one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying that the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and then cry at bedtime, and both belong to grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is often stuck for words more than cold, and colleagues who avoid the subject when someone returns after a death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been erased. A whole community can grieve together too, when a town loses its library or its factory.

On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people around you. When you are carrying it alone, it helps to give the day a small shape, with one meal, one walk and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help too, and nobody else ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is allowed.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening may help.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Grief and later life · For a hard evening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

If you want to help someone else with this

Show up, and then keep showing up. Support tends to flood in for two weeks and then stop, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal. Offer something specific; "Can I drop off dinner on Thursday?" is far easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything." Say the name. Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear the name of the person they lost, and a memory of them, and if you're unsure, ask. Leave out the explanations, because "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt, while "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does. And if you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss rather than on those closest to it. Comfort goes in towards the centre; venting goes out.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you

can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If a loss involved violence, or you are grieving a relationship you left because you weren't safe, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help, including after you separate (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#after-separation).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home? · after you separate
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for a wave that feels too big

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/upset-right-now

More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family · Family rifts after a loss or a will
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve · For teens
- **Big changes:** Empty nest · Retired together · Coming home after time apart · New parent
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill · Caring for someone you love
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 81) · Minds that work differently (Book 1, Chapter 7, page 117)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Grief and family · Helping children grieve
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Family rifts after a loss or a will
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

ONLINE
Retired together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
New parent
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging — Understanding Each Other, page 61
Why losing a bond hurts so much

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well — Understanding Each Other, page 115
Supporting someone who is grieving

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma — page 49
When grief turns into low mood

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from — Know Yourself Kindly, page 9
Losses that shaped your lens

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss-in-depth

5

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 5

Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.

- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THURSDAY, 2AM

It was one sentence, three weeks ago, said over someone's shoulder in a kitchen at a party, and they've probably forgotten it. You haven't. It plays again word for word, along with every clever thing you could have said back, and you're tired of carrying it around without knowing how to put it down.

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works and how relationships mend, and at how you can heal with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones. If someone is hurting you on purpose, or you feel afraid, start with safety first: Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

01

Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether the person, your trust or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them, and to keep you safe from the next one. Healing rarely runs in a straight line. The feeling can come back on an anniversary, or when something reminds you, and that doesn't mean you've failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel at a party, Kwesi feels a jolt when the song that was playing comes on the radio. He tells himself it's an old bruise being pressed. He turns the volume down and goes back to chopping onions. When a hurt replays for you, notice it, name it ("there's that memory again"), and bring your attention to something in the room you can see or touch.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

02

Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time. People snap and forget and misread each other, and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way: breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than it did before the break.

A dad snaps at his son for knocking a full glass of orange juice across the breakfast table. Twenty minutes later he sits down next to him on the sofa and says, "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair. Spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?" They

go and do it together, and the boy pours, very carefully, with his tongue out. Think of a small break from this week, with anyone, and go back and mend it with one sentence.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Can I have a do-over? That came out badly." "I didn't like how I spoke to you earlier. I'm sorry."

03

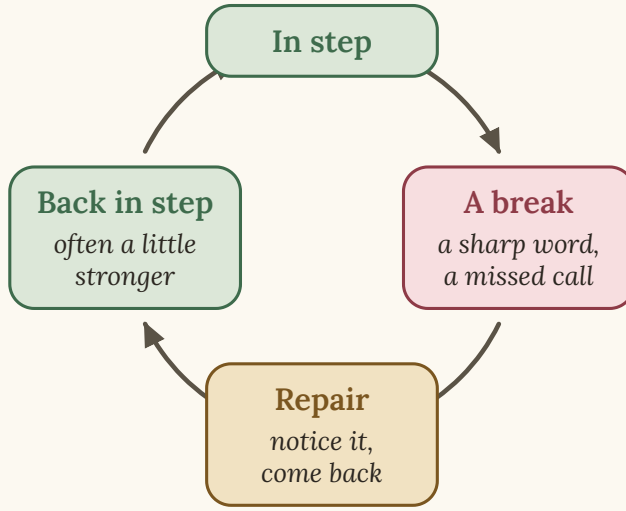
Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance, and it works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, leaving out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of an argument.

Amara says to her friend, on a walk rather than over the phone, "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." She had a stronger word ready. She leaves it out and sticks to what happened and what she needs, and her friend, who had honestly thought she was helping, goes red and apologises.

Every close relationship has breaks

What counts is coming back.



A real apology

Name it	Own it	Mend it
say what you did	*no "but"*	*now and next time*

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

Everyday breaks and repairs show up in parent and baby play (Tronick), in couples (Gottman's "repair attempts") and in therapy (Eubanks and colleagues, 2018).

FIGURE 6 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"When… happened, I felt… What I'd like is…" "I'm telling you because I want us to be okay."

Before you say it, it helps to write it in three short lines: what happened, how you felt, what you'd like.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Write it through

Carys, writing to her brother Owen

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Owen

Your name (optional)
Carys

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)
At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)
Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
I'm not angry with you as a person.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

04

A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand how it affected the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

Leila presented a shared idea at the Tuesday meeting as if it were hers, and saw her colleague's face. The next day she tells him, "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it was joint work."

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "I did… That was my doing. I can see it left you feeling… Here's what I'll do."

Next time you say sorry, check it has all four parts in it. Apology languages has more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. Rewind the talk can help you find those words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Apology languages
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages



TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying that what happened was okay, or forgetting it, or trusting the person again, or keeping them in your life. It's a

choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on anyone else's timetable.

Danielle forgave her father for missing much of her childhood. She still keeps his visits short, and she still won't leave her children alone with him when he has been drinking, and for her the forgiving and the protecting sit together without strain.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

If you're weighing it up, write down what forgiving someone would mean to you, and what it wouldn't. Seeing the difference can make it feel possible. It can also show you that you aren't ready, which is fine.

06

You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck, because the person may be gone, or unwilling to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe and decide what it means for you now.

After a hard breakup, Martha writes a letter she never sends, four pages in biro: what hurt, what she'd hoped for, what she's taking with her. She folds it into the back of a notebook, and over the following weeks she reaches for it less and less, and then one day realises she hasn't for a month.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I don't need them to understand for my healing to count."

Writing works for a lot of people. Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes on three or four days in a row, the facts and the feelings both. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop and talk to someone instead.

07

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in many small moments where someone does what they said they would do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture, and if you were let down, it is fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner for most of a year. After it came out, he started leaving his bank statement on the kitchen table on the first of each month, without being asked. Nobody made a speech about it. After a year of small, steady openness, his partner says, one evening, that she can breathe again.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I know my words aren't enough. I want to show you, over time." "I need to see it for a while before I can feel it."

08

Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship or change its shape. You can also step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go. The second time, forty pounds for a train ticket, she said, "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house," and they still share the Sunday roast most weeks.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I'm not angry any more, and I'm not going back to how it was."
> "I need some distance while I work out what I want."

Three questions can guide what comes next: is it safe, has the hurt stopped, and do you want this relationship in your life? If you feel unsafe, see signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

09

Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep or a jumpy feeling that won't settle. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest, food, movement, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you would talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful, and some don't. Neither is a test you can fail.

A man shouted at Idris on the top deck of the bus and called him names, and nobody else said a word. For days afterwards he felt shaky. He told a friend, went for long walks after work, and kept

reminding himself that it was about the man on the bus and that he was safe now. Over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded, though he sat downstairs for a while.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This was hard. Anyone would be shaken. What do I need right now?"

Pick one small act of care for today, an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now?

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologise or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

You've written it all down, every word of it. Then a much smaller version. "When you said that, I felt small. I'd like you to know." You still haven't decided whether to send it. It sits in your drafts, between a half-written email to the council and a shopping list. The two o'clock replays have gone a little quieter since it went onto paper.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Fine all day, falling apart at home

FROM OUTSIDE At work or school they're fine. At home they melt down or go silent.

THE LOGIC Fitting in all day takes effort that doesn't show → The effort is held in until it is safe to stop → Home feels safe, so the holding lets go → The crash shows that home is trusted

IT'S LIKE Holding your breath underwater and gasping at the surface.

WHY IT FITS Autistic adults describe "camouflaging" followed by exhaustion, and many other people do a version of it too.

THE OTHER SIDE The family gets the hardest part of the day.

YOU COULD SAY *"I hold it together all day. Home is where I can stop."*

ONE SMALL STEP A quiet half hour after getting home, with no questions. Later, a line like "That wasn't about you" helps.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=mask-crash

In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong. Can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologise so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you

something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter.
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
How to apologise so it counts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Listen before you advise.** "That sounds really painful" helps more than "You should just let it go."
- **Don't rush forgiveness.** Pushing someone to forgive can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter.
- **Don't push them to cut someone off, either.** It's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger.
- **If you caused the hurt,** give a real apology and then give them time. Don't ask them to make you feel better about it.

- **If they mention fear, threats or control,** take it seriously and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help takes some strength. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past. The page Free, private people to talk to (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#talk) includes specialist lines.

- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If anyone is in danger now, call your local emergency number.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Free, private people to talk to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts · For grown-up children
- **After a breakup:** On my own · Co-parenting
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe. Not safe at home?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Adult siblings and family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Foster, adoptive and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship



ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
Covering kindly and saying it out loud
Share the Load, page 73

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works
Repair in everyday talk
Understanding Each Other, page 25

Chapter 2 · Anger
When anger did the damage
page 29

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Guilt without shame
Know Yourself Kindly, page 81

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Apology languages
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth

6

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

MONDAY, 7:05AM

The plan was a walk before work. The trainers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7:40 you're still scrolling, past a video of a man restoring a rusty axe, next to a cup of coffee that went cold twenty minutes ago. By evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything. What you actually ran into this morning was a habit with years of practice behind it, and it won.

This chapter is the reason several tools in these books are so small. One small step a week (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 47) starts smaller than feels useful and decides ahead of time. The setup score and One owner per job (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) change the setup rather than asking anyone for more willpower. And What keeps coming back? (Book 4, Chapter 5, page 95) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are a normal part of changing anything.

01

Change is hard for good reasons.

Much of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, and it's the whole reason habits exist. The downside is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so change asks your brain to do something effortful again and again, for weeks, until the new way becomes the easy one.

Jodie wants to stop snapping at her children in the morning rush, and she means it every night. Every morning the same rush brings the same snap, somewhere between the lost reading book and the cold toast, because the morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This is hard because it's a habit." "Old grooves take time to fill in."

Pick one thing you'd like to change and write down when it usually happens, where, and what's going on just before. That's the start of the next idea.

02

Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger: a time, a place, a feeling, a person, or the thing you've just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a little buzz) keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

A man notices that he reaches for the biscuit tin the moment he opens his laptop after dinner, hungry or not. The laptop is the cue. So he starts making a pot of tea before he opens it, and the biscuits, mostly, stay in the tin. For three days, each time your habit happens, jot down the time, the place, the feeling and what you were doing just before.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "What happened right before I did that?" "What was I getting from it?"

03

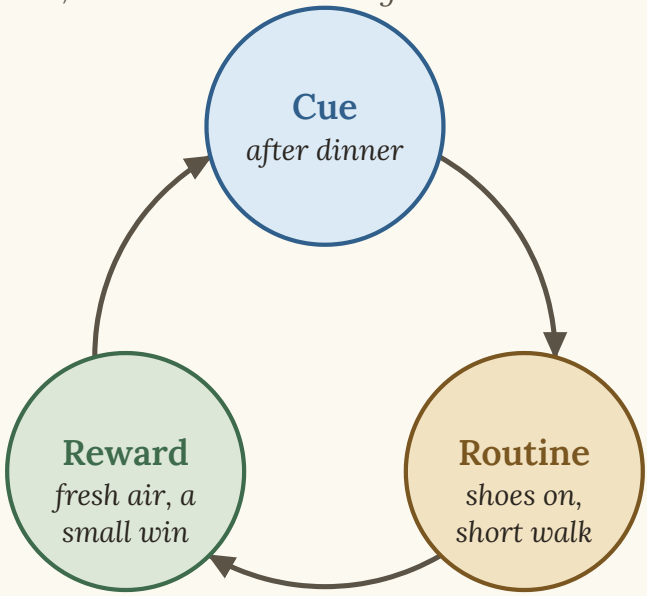
Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring but easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work because they are easy enough to do on a bad day. It helps to tie the new step to something you already do, as in "After I put the kettle on, I'll…", and to grow it only once it has stuck.

Two housemates want a tidier kitchen. They've been promising each other a big Sunday clean since March, and it has happened once. So they agree instead that after dinner each of them wipes one surface. It takes two minutes. By the second week the hob has stopped being a source of tension, and by the fourth somebody has descaled the kettle without being asked.

Habits run on cues

Over time, the cue alone is enough.



Change the setup, not just your willpower:
move the cue, make the step tiny.

The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).

FIGURE 7 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

YOU COULD SAY

"Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I ..., I will ..."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Your done list

Bernie, 71, living on his own

Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe

Who it was with

With a friend

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.

Fill in your own: Your done list

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE

Your done list

spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when you're tired or hungry. Your surroundings stay the same all day. So make the new habit easier, by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder, by moving it out of reach or adding a step. I'd back a small change to the setup over a big push of effort almost every time.

A teenager wants to sleep better and has tried for weeks to stop scrolling in bed. Then he starts charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, next to the bread bin, and within a week he's asleep before midnight most nights. He grumbles about it. He also keeps doing it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> (to yourself or a partner) "What could we change about the setup so this gets easier?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn't, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, or protect you from something. Pushing harder against that part rarely works, while listening to it often does.

Asif wants to drink less, but he also loves Friday evenings in the pub with his team. When he asks himself what Friday gives him, the answer is friends, laughter and a way to unwind, so he keeps the Friday and switches to alcohol-free after the first pint. Nobody at the table notices, or if they do, nobody says.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "What does the old habit give me?" "What would make the change worth it to me?"

Try two lists, one of what you like about how things are and one of what you'd like about changing. Both lists are allowed, and the first one is usually more honest.

06

Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo your progress. What often does the damage is the thought that follows, the "I've blown it, so why bother?" Treating yourself kindly after a slip makes it more likely that you will start again.

After three calm weeks, a dad shouts at his son over homework. That night he sits on the end of the bed and says, "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." The next evening they do the homework at the kitchen table with the radio on, and nobody raises their voice.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

Decide now, while things are going well, what you'll do after a slip: one kind sentence to yourself, and one small step to start again.



TIDBIT

A slip is a stumble, not a fall. Try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts can make the practising easier.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please others, or out of shame, is hard to keep. Change that connects to what you care about, to the kind of person you want to be, has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for that person.

A woman who keeps meaning to be better at keeping in touch starts thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. Sending one voice note on a Sunday evening becomes part of who she is, and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Who am I becoming with this step?" "This matters to me because..."

08

You can support change, but not force it.

It is natural to want the people we love to change, perhaps to drink less or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, ask what would help, and notice their small steps out loud.

A colleague keeps missing deadlines. His teammate has the lecture about being organised all ready to go, and skips it. She asks what would make the handover easier, and the two of them set up a shared checklist that he now updates every Friday before lunch.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

The trainers are still by the door, but the phone charges in the kitchen overnight now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on and out to the end of the road. Some mornings that is all you manage. Most mornings it turns into a walk past the allotments and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it that tomorrow you will get as far as the end of the road.

In everyday life

Take one couple who want to spend less time on their phones in the evening. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other, so this time they agree on a basket by the door where both phones go at nine, with one exception for whoever is on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward, and on the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football scores. By the third week the basket has become part of the furniture, and the evenings have a shape again, with a film, a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, a move or a new baby, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears and make the reward come straight away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter.

On your own: a kind plan for change

If you are working on something alone, the ideas fit into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it one cue, written as “After I ___, I will ___.” Make one tweak to your setup so it is easier to start, decide on the smallest version you could still do on a tired day, and write down one kind sentence to use after a slip. The self path and Know yourself, next (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 47) walk through this step by step.

SCAN TO OPEN



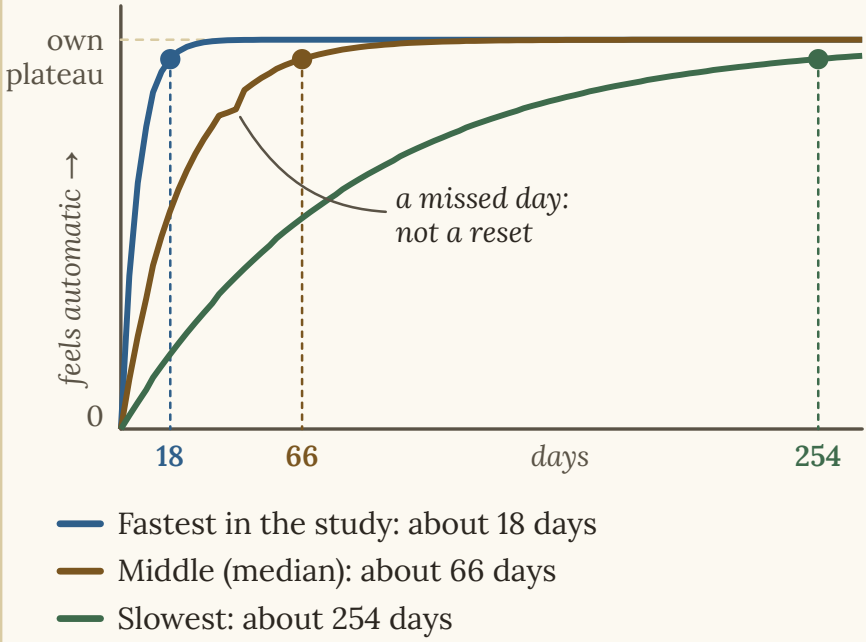
ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it" is the cruellest of these, and it's wrong. Wanting is only the start; habits, setup, tiredness and stress all have a vote. Then there's the famous 21 days. There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range. Being hard on yourself doesn't keep you on track either. Harshness tends to make people give up, and kindness makes it easier to try again. And routines don't have to mean being rigid. For a lot of people, autistic people especially, routines are what make life manageable, and change can respect that.

About two months, give or take a lot

How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.



- Fastest in the study: about 18 days
- Middle (median): about 66 days
- Slowest: about 254 days

Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.

FIGURE 8 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise, perhaps with "Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?", and help them find their own reasons by asking what would be different for them if this changed.

Practical help with the setup (a lift to the gym, say) often does more than encouragement alone. Notice small steps out loud and be kind about slips. Look after yourself as well, because you can care deeply and still set limits on what you will put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in, the quick checks and the self path can help you keep track.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

ONLINE
quick checks
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

ONLINE
the self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

More for your situation

- On my own
- New parents
- When a child has ADHD
- Neurodivergent relationships
- Gaming, phones and time together
- At work

- Coming home after time apart
- Find it by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Gaming, phones and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
Find it by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- ✓ **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- ✓ **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- ✓ **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly, page 47
One small goal and tiny steps

Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load, page 95
The monthly look-back

Book 4, Chapter 2 · Is the split working? — Share the Load, page 27
Changing the setup, not the person

Book 1, Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change — Know Yourself Kindly, page 99
How much people really change

PUT IT TO USE



Complacency
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth

7

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 7

Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Values are directions you keep walking in
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. When to get more help
12. Tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Values are directions you keep turning towards.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.

- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

The week ahead is full: the MOT on Tuesday, a dentist, two late meetings, your turn for the school run. None of it feels like yours. You aren't sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, rather than because it was next on the list.

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology and from philosophy, which has been asking how we should live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. I've tried to keep the old names to a minimum and the words plain.

01

Values are directions you keep walking in.

A goal is something you can tick off, like painting the hall or passing a test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, such as looking after your health, making your home feel cared for or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind, and that's exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan planned to go to the gym three times this week and went once, and on Thursday evening, eating crisps on the sofa in her gym kit, she felt like a failure. When she asked herself what the gym was for, the answer was looking after her body so that she had energy for her children. On Friday she walked for twenty minutes at lunchtime, round the park behind the office, and it counted. If

you have a goal that has stalled, try asking "what is this for?" three times in a row, and write down where you end up.

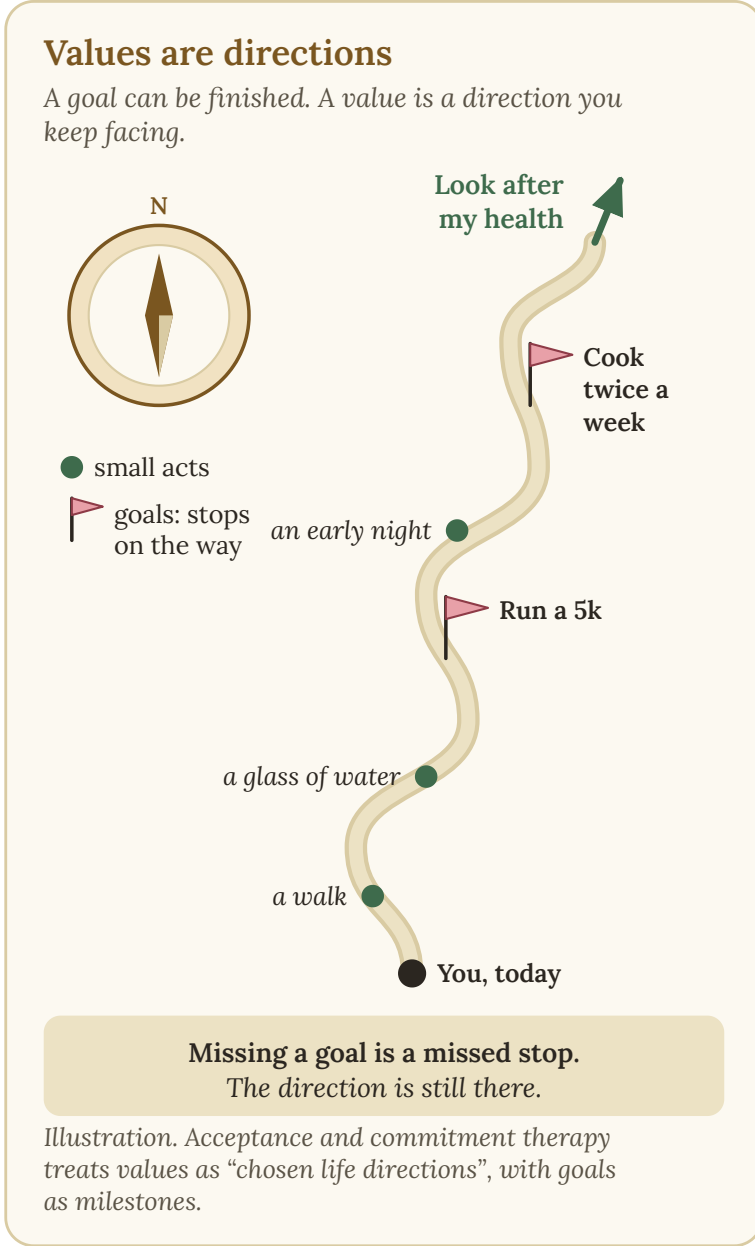


FIGURE 9 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way; missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from nothing. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness tends to show what you love. Sacha is furious when a colleague takes credit for the team's work. Under the anger is a value, which is fairness and seeing people's effort, and once he names it he can raise fairness at the next team meeting instead of seething at one person for a week. He might say, "I think I'm upset because fairness really matters to me, more than winning this one."

Think of the last time you felt strongly, in a good way or a bad one, and finish the sentence "That mattered to me because I care about…"

03

Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't between a good thing and a bad one. They're between two good things, honesty and kindness, say, or family and rest. Feeling torn usually just means you care about more than one thing, and even when you choose well it's normal to feel a little sad about the side you didn't pick. A mum cares about being honest and about protecting her eight-year-old. When the family dog is very ill, she finds a way to honour both and tells the truth gently, in words a child can hold. "Biscuit is very poorly. The vet is helping, and we'll look after him together."

If you feel stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. It often helps to ask whether you can honour some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. It's one of the oldest ideas in this book and still one of the most useful. (I spent my career as a government auditor, and the sorting matters there too: mix up two different problems and you keep solving the wrong one.) Your own choices and how you treat people are up to you. Other people's choices, and the weather, and the past, are not. Worry tends to collect in the second pile, and values do their work in the first. Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas with her family, and she can't make him enjoy it. She can plan a shorter visit, put a long muddy walk on Boxing Day into it, which he'll like, and be warm herself. That's her part, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

One way to try this is to write a worry in two columns, the parts that are up to you and the parts that aren't, then pick one small thing from the first column and do it.

05

A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. Many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists today, also describe a second kind of wellbeing, which comes from growing, using your strengths, being a good friend and doing things that matter even when they are hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought we build it the way we build any skill, by practice, a little at a time. Jade spent a month of evenings helping a friend move out of a damp, unhappy flat, scrubbing black mould off a bathroom ceiling and carrying boxes down three flights. It was tiring and not much fun. When she looks back on her year, she counts it among the best months of it.

Tonight you might write down one thing that felt good today and one that felt worthwhile, and notice whether they turn out to be the same thing.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, put philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favourite rainy-day pastimes.

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Learn by doing: connect two fields of study
spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

06

Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it. Your life makes some sense to you, you are heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles that others count on, far more than from big moments. Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went quiet. Now he reads to children at the library one morning a week, which gives him a reason to iron a shirt on Tuesday nights and a small group of people who notice when he isn't there.

Try listing the roles you play, big or small (neighbour, sister, the one who waters the office plants), and next to each one write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Keep your little rituals alive

Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together

Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
Lachlan

Person B
Sunita

Date
2 October 2026

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way
Monday coffee call, cameras optional	*Weekly*	*Fading*	*Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30*
Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat	*Weekly*	*Alive*	*Five minutes; people notice each other's work*
A card and lunch when someone leaves	*Now and then*	*Alive*	*People leave feeling thanked*
Office day with lunch together	*Monthly*	*Stopped*	*Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests*
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day	*Daily*	*New idea*	*So nobody wonders who's around*

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

Your rituals
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

Fading or stopped
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

New ideas
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
Monday coffee call

The smallest version that still counts
Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
Office day with lunch together

What it gave us
A day all together, back when we all lived near the office

The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-15 · free to print
Keep your little rituals alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

07

Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, with one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and that they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad. Jasper values a calm, tidy home, and his housemate Darnell values an open door and friends dropping by. For months each privately thought of the other as messy or uptight. Once they named what each of them cared about, they could make a plan, and Friday nights became open house while Sundays stayed quiet.

In your next disagreement, it may help to ask, "What matters to you about this?", and to listen for the value underneath the position.

08

Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again, such as how you greet people, whether you keep small promises and how you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care

said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you. At the supermarket an older man is struggling with the card machine, and the queue behind him is growing; someone near the back tuts. You wait without sighing and tell him there's no rush. It costs you about forty seconds.

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it each day this week. You'll drift. Everyone does. Turning back is the practice.



SUGARFOOT

A value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what that is for each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: what feels like care
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction. When you notice you've drifted, you can turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

You write three words on the back of an envelope, people, health and making things, and under each one a small thing for this week. Ring Gran. Walk on Wednesday. Finish the shelf in the spare room, the one that has been "nearly done" since Easter. The week is still full. You prop the envelope against the kettle, where you'll see it in the morning before you see anything else.

In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, such as security and adventure, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean quite different things by it, from living close by to being free to go, so it is worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

If you want to help someone else with this

Asking "What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud, as in "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than a lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued

family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

When to get more help

Feeling a bit lost or flat for a while is part of being human. But some signs mean it's worth talking to someone trained:

- Life has felt empty or pointless for more than two weeks, and things you used to enjoy don't reach you. That can be depression, which is common and treatable. A doctor or counsellor is a good first step.
- You have thoughts of not wanting to be alive. Please talk to someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.
- Someone in your life is pushing you to give up what matters to you, cutting you off from friends, or making you afraid to disagree. That's about control. It has nothing to do with values. The page When it's more than a rough patch (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) can help you think it through.

Some therapies, such as acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), work directly with values. A counsellor can help you find yours when everything feels foggy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
When it's more than a rough patch
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Your self-discovery path, step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own · Empty nest · A new chapter after loss
- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together

- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family · Coming out as an adult
- **Friends and work:** Friends · At work
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens · Growing up
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

ONLINE
A new chapter after loss
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
Turning values into one small goal

Know Yourself Kindly, page 47

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
Two kinds of fair
Share the Load, page 73

Book 3, Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture
Whose values a group rewards
Understanding Each Other, page 97

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Worth that is not a score
Know Yourself Kindly, page 81

PUT IT TO USE

Your self-discovery path
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values-in-depth

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

How do I tell ordinary stress from something that needs help?

Stress that comes and goes with what is happening, and eases when the pressure lifts, is part of life. When it hangs on after the pressure has gone, or sleep, appetite and mood stay off for weeks, it is worth a word with your doctor. Every chapter in this book has a short part called "When to get more help", and Stress and the nervous system (Chapter 1, page 9) is a good place to begin.

I lost my temper and said something I regret. Is it too late to put it right?

It rarely is. A short apology that names what you did, without a "but", and a plan for next time go a long way, even days later. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page 85) shows how a repair goes, and Anger (Chapter 2, page 29) has a pause plan for the next time the heat rises.

Someone I love is grieving. What should I say?

Something simple and true, such as "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." Saying the name of the person who died is usually a kindness. Practical help, like a meal, a lift or a walk, often means more than the right words, and so does still being there a few months on. Loss, grief and big life changes (Chapter 4, page 69) has more.

I keep starting good habits and dropping them. What am I doing wrong?

Probably nothing, except starting too big. Habits stick when the first step is tiny, tied to something you already do and easy to restart after a missed day. Habits and change (Chapter 6, page 105) shows how to shrink a step until it takes two minutes or less.

Do I have to forgive someone who hurt me?

No. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time, and you can heal even if the other person never says sorry. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page 85) explains what forgiving means and what it doesn't.

Where can I find help quickly?

The help page at the front of this book (page 7) has the numbers to call, including in an emergency. For everything else, Help beyond this book lists counsellors,

helplines and support groups, and most of them are free.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help beyond this book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Habits and change (page 105)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Anger (page 29), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 49)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Habits and change (page 105)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 121)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder
In: Healing after hurt (page 85)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 49)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 121)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 121)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Anger (page 29), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 49), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 69), Healing after hurt (page 85), Habits and change (page 105)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page 29)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 49), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 69)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Healing after hurt (page 85)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 69), Healing after hurt (page 85)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 121)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Habits and change (page 105)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`

In: Healing after hurt (page **85**)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Anger (page **29**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **49**), Habits and change (page **105**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **121**)

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page **121**)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

Calm-down plan

Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or “Can we start over?”

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 149 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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